

Migration, AI Guardian Spirits, and the Future of the Vietnamese Communal House

Background Information

The Thành Hoàng Làng and the Đình

In Vietnamese culture, honoring ancestors and showing respect to local history are some of the most essential cultural expectations. More specifically, a major part of this traditional identity revolves around the Thanh Hoang Lang, which is the protective guardian deity found in almost all Vietnamese villages. Traditionally, many of these protective deities are honored inside the communal house, which is known by locals as the Dinh. Additionally, in villages, the Dinh is known as the spiritual heart of the village where neighbors gather to resolve disputes and hold seasonal festivals annually. For centuries, interacting with a spiritual guardian has required a person to be physically present with other members of the community.

However, due to rapid modernization, the movement of young people to urban centers is changing how communities are staying connected and honoring their roots. For instance, according to national demographic surveys, rural-to-urban movement accounts for 36.2% of all internal migration flows in Vietnam, which is three times larger than urban-to-rural migration (General Statistics Office and UNFPA). As a result, in order to prevent many traditions from disappearing, many groups are converting historical sites into a digital space. For example, tech initiatives like the VR3D project have started creating three-dimensional scans of ancient communal houses, which allows people to explore spiritual places on a digital platform (VR3D).

The Philosophical Problem

Over time, as these AI tools continue to advance, developers are working towards using artificial intelligence to create interactive chatbots that let a person have a live conversation with a simulated version of a guardian deity. While this innovation makes cultural learning more accessible for individuals living in urban areas, it also creates a serious philosophical problem. In particular, when a village guardian spirit is turned into an automated app, we have to ask whether it actually honors ancestors or reduces sacred connections to an online application.

Jean Baudrillard and the Problem of Simulation

Simulation and Hyperreality

One compelling argument is rooted in the philosophy of Jean Baudrillard, a philosopher who studied how modern media and technology reshape our perception of reality. Baudrillard introduced a famous concept known as simulation and hyperreality, in which he explained that in the modern world, society often replaces

real objects and genuine human experiences with digital platforms (Baudrillard). More specifically, Baudrillard explains that a simulation happens when a representation or a copy of something becomes more prominent than the actual item itself. In other words, the digital copy of a concept or item would be so advanced that it might be capable of hiding the fact that the original concept is missing. This is known as hyperreality, when people prefer the digital copy over the original idea (Baudrillard).

Applying Baudrillard's philosophy to a village guardian spirit application, we can see that a traditional Thanh Hoang Lang is deeply tied to the physical land of the village and the history of the local communal house. Consequently, when software development introduces a 3D model of the same Thanh Hoang Lang within a digital realm, it would produce a simulation of the spirit. More specifically, the app enables a person to talk and honor a Thanh Hoang Lang through a screen, but it does not actually have a real connection to the place itself since the spiritual value of a Thanh Hoang Lang resides in a local communal house rather than a device.

Overall, Baudrillard's ideas warn us that the action of relying on a digital application to worship a village deity might replace the activity of visiting local communal houses. More specifically, this technological shortcut can cover up the need to physically honor our ancestors, which hides the reality that we are unintentionally blurring the physical connection we have to ancestral villages (Baudrillard).

Byung-Chul Han and the Disappearance of Rituals

Why Rituals Hold a Community Together

Another important idea is put forward by Byung-Chul Han, a contemporary philosopher who examines how digital communication affects human relationships. In his book *The Disappearance of Rituals*, Han writes about the disappearance of traditional rituals in modern society. He argues that real rituals are extremely important because they create a sense of stability and bring individuals together into a physical community (Han). More precisely, a traditional festival at a communal house is meaningful because it requires physical labor and face-to-face interaction between neighbors who organized activities together. Han adds that these actions create a social bond that cannot be replicated online (Han).

Han points out that digital technology destroys meaningful rituals by encouraging solitary habits. Han explains that when a person uses an AI app to interact with a village guardian spirit, that person might transform a shared community practice into an isolated interaction through a device (Han). In particular, a digital app enables a person to honor and potentially receive guidance from the village guardian online without needing to interact with relatives or village neighbors.

According to Han's philosophy, the shift toward making village guardian 3D models available online changes the purpose of a tradition. By removing the physical gathering of the community, the automated tool weakens the social bond that made the guardian spirit meaningful in the first place.

Counterpoint: Shannon Vallor and Technomoral Wisdom

Virtue at a Distance

Although there are several arguments pointing out the disadvantages of preserving traditions through digital platforms, some philosophers believe that technology can still be beneficial. Shannon Vallor, a modern philosopher who focuses on technology ethics and how humans can practice virtues in a digital world, challenges the view that electronic devices always ruin a person's moral relationships. Instead, Vallor introduces the concept of technomoral wisdom, arguing that people can use new tools to expand their ability to practice virtues such as reverence and care across large distances (Vallor).

To be more specific, when observing the current situation in Vietnam, many young adults are leaving their rural provinces to find work or attend university in distant cities, which is making it very difficult for them to visit their home communal houses on important anniversary events. For example, the national migration data indicates that over 40 percent of internal migrants cross provincial borders, meaning that it is impractical to cover hundreds of kilometers regularly to attend a tradition ("Results of the Population and Housing Census 2019"). Because of this predicament, many of these individuals would choose an interactive application or a virtual tour of a historic site as a way to participate in cultural traditions.

In summary, Vallor's philosophy suggests that using an AI assistant to study the history of a village guardian spirit and to honor one's ancestors is an effective way to maintain a sense of cultural reverence even when a person cannot physically be at the village. Vallor states that these technologies help keep the memory of the village protector alive in the modern era by giving the younger generation opportunities to honor traditions and ancestors while not having to be physically present (Vallor).

Conclusion

Two Ways of Weighing the Trade

When observing this topic from a wider scope, it is clear that there is a dilemma between deep historical traditions and the reality of young people moving far away to large cities for work. According to the ideas of Baudrillard and Han, outsourcing spiritual practices to an AI chatbot can unintentionally weaken the values of village traditions (Baudrillard; Han). Moreover, these philosophers remind us that an algorithm on a smartphone cannot mimic the physical warmth that the social unity of a village festival brings. On the other hand, from the perspective of Shannon Vallor, she contends that digital tools can be essential for the younger generation, who are separated from their rural roots, to honor and connect to their villages and traditions (Vallor).

Ultimately, whether interacting with a village guardian spirit online preserves or ruins sacred tradition depends on how a person defines what cultural respect really is. To be more specific, an AI algorithm cannot feel reverence or recreate physical community presence, so it is incapable of providing genuine spiritual connection. However, interactive apps help adults who work in urban areas maintain their heritage by

providing them a way to honor their ancestors while working far from home. Consequently, it is up to the younger generations to decide whether cultural devotion lives in physical presence or in keeping local memory alive from afar.

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